

CULTIVARS

- Astro
- Esmee
- Voyager

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 12 rows (2"- 6 cm) apart spaced every 1.5" (4 cm) on the row
- 6 row seeder (C-O-T); Hole Size C, Outboard pulleys, Tight brush setting

FERTILIZATION

- Arugula will do great in beds that were previously amended with compost and his fertilized with a mix of alfalfa meal (2-0-2) meal and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).
- When planning for more than 2 cuts on the same crop, adding a layer of compost (+/-1"- 2.5 cm & absolutely weed free) to your beds and seeding directly into it will help keep the crop strong and weed free.

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tapes: 4 per bed.
- Sprinkler may throw dirt on foliage.

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Shallow (6"-24")
- General: Frequent shallow watering to maintain flavour, succulence and support rapid growth. Critical to water Throughout during hot days.

IMPLANTATION

For a continuous supply of really nice arugula, we seed every week with an estimated 30% more than our weekly sales target. When needed, we will make a second cut on a bed, but the first one is always better.

In our program, arugula is seeded alongside turnips, radishes, and other baby Asian greens, all crops that will stay in the field for less than 45 days and that belong to the brassicaceae family. They therefore have the same fertilization and plant protection requirements.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- 6 row seeder, scale, notepad and your seeds
- 30" rake
- Anti-insect netting (or row cover in the spring)

ITINERARY

- Remove tarp and clean large debris. Use the rake if needed. *
- Uniformly apply amendments and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 1" (3 cm). Rake the bed carefully, removing all debris; soil clods, rocks, roots, etc. Beds need to be perfectly clean, levelled and firm for optimal usage of the 6-row seeder.
- Only seed when the bed surface is dry (if not, seeds will stick, and the seeder won't work properly). It's good practice to roll over the seed bed with the 6-row (without any seeds) in order to firm the seed bed and to make sure that it won't clog.
- Before seeding, take time to carefully adjust the 6-row seeder. To minimize uncertainty, we don't play around with the whole size, nor do we adjust the depth of the planting. The brush, however, should be adjusted every time you seed.
- The gap under the brush (T—tight, N—normal, L—loose) should always be less than half the size of the seed being sown. For arugula, we set it to T. To adjust the brush, turn it clockwise to open it more or counterclockwise to close it.
- To make sure that all six hoppers are feeding at the same rate, fill all of them with the exact same number of seeds. After seeding halfway in your first pass, adjust the brushes until all six are feeding at the same rate.
- Cover with anti-insect netting, install irrigation and water the soil until it is deeply moistened.

* If the previous crop is too well established, or if the bed is too messy, mow the crop as low as possible and harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). Add 1" (2.5 cm) of compost evenly spread on the whole width of the bed and transplant into compost following a no-till strategy.

WEEDING

- Unlike radishes and turnips that are seeded at the same time, arugula cannot tolerate any weed pressure. Because we harvest quickly and efficiently using the greens harvester, there is no time to be picking through the crop for weeds.
- Tarping seed beds with black plastic for 2 weeks prior to seeding date is a good first start in diminishing weed pressure in your arugula. Using the stale seed bed technique (forcing the weeds to pop up before you plant) is another good practice. If weeds continue to be a problem, planting arugula directly onto weed-free compost is another good option.
- In any case, cultivate using the flex tine weeder +/- 10 days after direct seeding the crop, and again 5 days later. Make at least 2 passes each time.

PLANT PROTECTION

- To protect the crop against flea beetles, cover the bed with anti-insect netting (or row cover) immediately after seeding.
- This practice is even more effective if the bed is irrigated before installing the net, as the water will chase away the flea beetles. The more tightly the sides are sealed, the better the results will be.

HARVEST

- The arugula is harvested when the leaves measure between 3" and 5" (8 and 13 cm) long.
- Use the quick-cut greens harvester with a new or very sharp blade.
- When using the tool, make sure that the blade doesn't touch the ground and ALWAYS pay attention not to have stems longer than 2' (5 cm).
- With a well-sharpened blade and a clean bed, one person should harvest at least 100 lbs/per hour.
- After the harvesting is done, pass over the cut area using a rake to remove the debris. Performing this operation ensures a second clean cut.

CONDITIONING

- In the conditioning station, place arugula adjacent to the washing tub. Fill the tub with clean potable water, adding a microbicide sanitizer. The sanitizer will kill any possible pathogens and will extend the shelf life of the arugula.
- Before starting, wash your hands and/or gloves and sterilize the surfaces using a disposable cloth and an antiseptic soap spray.
- Mix your batch in the tub, checking for and removing any debris, insects or yellowed leaves. It is worth it to take extra time at this step and to be vigilant.
- Do not let the arugula soak for longer than 3–4 minutes, otherwise it will become waterlogged. Depending on how much you've harvested, this can mean only washing one bin of arugula at a time.
- Remove the arugula using orange baskets and spin for one cycle in the washing machine (+/- 3 minutes). The baskets need to be filled halfway or less (otherwise the arugula doesn't dry enough).
- During the first cycle, fill the other baskets so the leaves can drain while they're waiting for their turn in the machine.
- Empty the dry arugula in the bagging bin and start bagging while the other drying cycles are underway.
- When bagging ½ lb bags: weigh within 0.1 lbs (20 gr) not to waste too much time. Always leave a bit of air in the bag and tie it twice: the first time very tightly (to close the bag securely) and a second time looser (only tight enough to secure the first knot). Each bag must be easy to open, so that clients don't have to tear them.
- When bagging kilo bags (2.2 lbs): once filled, bags are sealed using a sealer.
- In both instances, make sure a farm sticker has been put on each bag. Putting stickers on bags can be done ahead of time in the winter months.

STORING

- Arugula is stored in a cold room at 35 °F (2 °C) and should not be kept for more than 3 days before being sold.